



Niujie mosque

One of the oldest mosques in China, Niujie was originally built in the 10th century CE. While Islamic empires never extended their influence to China, strong trade links between the two cultures ensured that Islam gained a foothold in East Asia.



Hassan tower

The huge 12th-century tower at Rabat in Morocco was designed as a minaret for an enormous mosque that was never completed.

Qutb Minar minaret

The Qutb Minar in Delhi, India, is the world's tallest brick minaret. The tower and mosque complex were built in the early 13th century by the founder of the Delhi sultanate.

AFTER



Great Mosque of Djenné

Although the current mosque at Djenné in Mali is just over a century old, it stands on the site of a mosque first built in 1240. Following its construction, Djenné became West Africa's most important seat of Islamic learning.

Syria, Ethiopia, and the Maghreb, and is still considered the most prestigious site of Islamic learning in the world.

The Fatimid dynasty continued to rule Egypt until their conquest by the Kurdish warrior Saladin in 1171. Saladin used his Egyptian base to retake the Holy Land from the crusader settlers, but his Ayyubid dynasty fell within a century, overthrown by the Mamluks, originally Turkish slave soldiers, who had risen to become commanders of the Egyptian army.

The Umayyads in Spain

The emirate of Cordoba was founded in 756 by the exiled Umayyads, who ruled almost all of Spain. The title of

caliph was taken by 'Abd al-Rahman III al-Nasir in 929, possibly as a reaction to the claims of the Fatimids.

The blending of Islamic ideas with Christian and Spanish influences produced a unique cultural fusion across the areas ruled by the Umayyad and the Almoravids, their Moroccan successors. The visual arts of Islamic Spain are expressed most fully at the Alhambra (see above), a palace built for the rulers of the kingdom of Granada. Spain became the wellspring from which Islamic and pre-Islamic knowledge flowed back into medieval Europe, and the influence of highly civilized "Moorish" Spain extended into

neighboring Christian kingdoms. The availability of Islamic scholars and Arabic-speaking Christians made cities such as Toledo on the Moorish-Christian frontier a center for the translation of Arabic texts into Latin.

Other Muslim lands

As traders carried their religion across the ocean with their goods, Islamic belief moved east. The 13th century saw the establishment of an Islamic sultanate in Delhi (see pp.180–81). From here Islam spread into Southeast

Asia and the Indonesian archipelago. Muslim traders and missionaries also settled in western and eastern Africa, around Ghana, Senegal, and Sudan (see pp.182–83).

Hajj certificate

The *hajj*, or pilgrimage to Mecca, is one of the key duties of all Muslims. This certificate, dating from 1207 and depicting the Kaaba shrine, was proof that its owner had completed the pilgrimage.



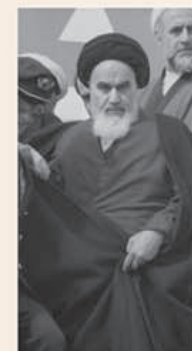
Islam has continued to play an influential role in world history until the present.

FATE OF THE CALIPHATES

The Mongols << 164–65 who invaded the Abbasid caliphate in the 13th century assimilated the local culture to become the Ilkhanid dynasty. The Mamluks halted the Mongol advance around 1260, and survived to be conquered in the 16th century by the Ottomans 206–07 >>. After 1031, the Spanish caliphate dissolved into smaller states that were slowly conquered by Spanish Christians, the last falling in 1492.

FUNDAMENTALISM

The late 20th century saw the rise of a politicized Islam, advocating strict adherence to the Qur'an and revolt against secular governments, as seen in the Iranian Revolution led by Ayatollah Khomeini 442–43 >>.



AYATOLLAH KHOMEINI